

THE CREATURE BEFORE GOD

Part III

At the End of Every Why

Charity and the Freedom of the Creature

A patristic, Thomistic, and mystical study

From commanded good, through grace and friendship,
to the love that returns to its source

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1 A Command Addressed to Desire

Being is gift. Justice answers gift with what is due. The due return names action brought into agreement with received being. Yet even a rightly performed act can coexist with a will divided from the good it serves. Neither justice nor obligation alone reaches the final question: not only *what must I do?*, but *what should I want?*

Scripture answers with a command. Israel is to love the Lord with the whole heart, soul, and strength; Christ names this the first and greatest commandment and joins it to love of neighbor (Deut 6:4–5; Matt 22:37–40). Love is not left as an elective refinement for those who have completed the serious work of obedience. The law itself is ordered toward it.

That creates an apparent contradiction. An external act can be compelled. Words can be repeated, tribute paid, attendance enforced, injury restrained. But an affection produced only by force is not love. If love must be free, how can it be owed? If it is owed, how can it remain free?

The contradiction depends upon an equivocation. Freedom does not mean that the will has no true end and no good to which it is ordered. Nor does command mean that an alien power manufactures the inward act it names. A person may be bound to tell the truth while lying willingly; obligation identifies the good without causing the will to embrace it. The command to love is more searching still. It addresses the principle from which the rest of moral life proceeds.

Aquinas confronts the difficulty directly. A precept concerns what is due, and union with God is the end of spiritual life. Charity, by which that union begins, may therefore be commanded. The obligation of the command is opposed to liberty only in a will averse from what is commanded. Love itself can be fulfilled only willingly (ST II–II, q. 44, a. 1, especially ad 2).

The object of the command must also be exact. Charity is not intense feeling, indulgence, attraction, or an affectionate name for whatever the will already prefers. It is the theological virtue by which God is loved above all things for God's own sake and the neighbor is loved in relation to God (ST II–II, q. 23, aa. 1 and 5; CCC 1822). Feeling may accompany charity, but neither emotional warmth nor its absence settles whether charity is present. The command reaches the will's fundamental direction.

Governing thesis

Charity is the graced freedom by which the creature comes to will the good that justice commands. It does not abolish what is due, and what is due cannot by itself produce charity. The Holy Spirit writes the law within, raises the servant into friendship, and makes possible an answer that is genuinely the creature's act yet remains entirely dependent upon grace—unequal to God's love, but capable by grace of being whole.

The governing distinction can therefore be stated tersely:

The command names the end.

Grace gives the capacity.

The creature must still answer.

Love may be commanded. It cannot be manufactured by an external command.

2 The Law Written Within

An external law can reveal the good, forbid its contrary, expose a refusal, and bind the person who refuses. These are real achievements. They do not, by themselves, heal the refusal. Adding imperatives cannot make a divided heart whole.

The prophets promise something more than a clearer inscription. Jeremiah speaks of a covenant in which God's law is written upon the heart. Ezekiel joins a new heart to the gift of God's Spirit, who enables the people to walk in the divine ways (Jer 31:31–34; Ezek 36:26–27). The promised transformation neither declares the commandments mistaken nor treats inward sincerity as a substitute for them. It brings the will into agreement with the good they name.

Augustine makes this the center of *On the Spirit and the Letter*. The law without assisting grace stands outside the will: it teaches and accuses, but cannot justify. When the life-giving Spirit is present, what was feared as an external demand becomes loved as an inward law. Augustine identifies the law written by God in the heart with the presence of the Holy Spirit, through whom charity is poured into us and the law is fulfilled (chs. 32–36). His famous petition in the *Confessions* is not an escape from responsibility: “Give what you command, and command what you will” (X.29.40). The command remains entire. Its fulfillment is confessed as gift.

Aquinas gathers that Augustinian claim into a definition of the New Law. What is chief in the law of the Gospel is not a text but the grace of the Holy Spirit given through faith in Christ. Written teaching remains necessary: it disposes persons to receive grace and directs them in its use. Yet the New Law does more than indicate what should be done. By grace it helps the person to do it (ST I–II, q. 106, a. 1).

Charity is therefore neither an achievement assembled from repeated natural acts nor a divine feeling substituted for human willing. It is infused by the Holy Spirit because friendship in God’s own beatitude exceeds the proportion of created nature (ST II–II, q. 24, a. 2). Grace heals the will wounded by sin and elevates it to a supernatural end; faith receives the divine self-disclosure, hope relies upon divine help for promised communion, and charity begins that communion in the will.

The word *infused* can sound as though the person were merely a vessel. Aquinas’s wider account of divine and created agency excludes that picture. God moves each thing according to its mode; when God moves a will, he does not turn willing into compulsion (ST I–II, q. 10, a. 4). Even the free turning by which a person prepares for grace requires gratuitous inward motion, yet remains genuinely voluntary (q. 109, a. 6). Grace does not love while the person remains inert. It makes possible a free act that nature cannot manufacture and does not cease to be the person’s act because its deepest source is received.

The apprehension of asymmetry has deepened. God gives both the good to be loved and the capacity to love it. The creature supplies no independent supernatural principle with which grace must bargain. Yet the result is not less personal. The will is most free not when indifferent to its fulfillment, but when it can embrace the true good without the bondage of a divided appetite.

The law written within is not a private oracle. It is the grace of Christ communicated through the Holy Spirit, received in faith and the sacramental life, and ordered toward acts that can be tested against the revealed command. An inward impulse that contradicts truth, justice, or love of neighbor does not become charity by feeling spontaneous.

Grace does not silence the command. It makes an answer possible.

3 No Longer Servants

At the Last Supper, command and friendship appear in the same speech. Christ tells the disciples to abide in his love by keeping his commandments, commands them to love one another as he has loved them, and then says that he no longer calls them servants but friends (John 15:9–17). Friendship does not arrive after obedience has been discarded. It names the communion into which obedience is being drawn.

Irenaeus saw the force of this conjunction. Christ does not abolish the natural precepts but extends them from external restraint to the desires of the heart. The liberated person remains subject to God; indeed, Irenaeus says the work of liberty is greater and more glorious than servile obedience. Servants and children owe piety to the same Lord, but children follow with confidence, and friends know what the Word has received from the Father (*Against Heresies* IV.13.1–4).

The transition benefits the creature, not God. Irenaeus immediately insists that God did not accept Abraham’s friendship out of need and does not profit from human service. The perfect God grants life to those who follow him; obedience perfects the servant rather than completing the Lord (IV.13.4; IV.14.1). Creaturely response remains asymmetric even at its most intimate.

Aquinas supplies friendship with a precise grammar. Not every love is friendship. Friendship requires willing the good of another, reciprocal love, and some communication or shared life. God communicates to creatures a participation in eternal beatitude; upon that gift a real friendship with God can be founded. This friendship is charity (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 1).

No equality of nature follows. The communication is first given by God, charity in the soul is created, and the final

good remains possessed by God as source and by the creature through participation (q. 23, a. 2; q. 24, a. 2). Christ remains Lord when he calls the disciples friends. The Creator-creature distinction is not relaxed so that communion can begin. Communion is possible because divine transcendence is not rivalry and grace can perfect a creature without making it uncreated.

What changes is the creature's manner of willing. Fear of punishment becomes servile when punishment is shunned as the chief evil; mercenary love calculates the wage. Filial fear dreads separation from the beloved; charity cleaves to divine goodness itself. Augustine holds that punitive fear recedes as charity grows and is cast out when charity is perfected, while chaste fear remains watchful not to lose communion with the beloved (*Homilies on First John* IX.4–6). Aquinas gives the distinction formal precision: charity casts out servility; fear of punishment may remain but diminishes as charity grows; filial fear increases (ST II–II, q. 19, a. 10). The *Catechism* describes the same passage from slave and wage-seeker to child and friend (CCC 1828, 1972).

Aquinas carries the distinction to its limit in the blessed. Punitive anxiety is excluded, yet wonder before divine supereminence and incomprehensibility remains, accompanied by security and the tranquillity of charity. The infinite disproportion between creature and Creator remains, and with it reverent subjection (q. 19, a. 11). Love does not make the disproportion smaller. At the limit, reverent wonder remains while punitive anxiety does not.

This does not make fear of punishment useless at the beginning of conversion or every imperfect motive sinful. Nor does it imply that a person in charity enjoys constant sensible closeness to God. The theological virtue is not measured by felt intimacy. Friendship names an objective participation and a stable orientation of will, lived through acts that may be costly, obscure, and dry.

The decisive claim is narrower and stronger. Obligation can still be experienced as alien even when the good it protects is intellectually recognized. Charity does not remove the command. It begins to remove the distance between the will and the good. The friend obeys because he has begun to share, by grace, in the good the command protects.

Friendship does not remove asymmetry. It removes alienation from the good.

4 Charity Gives Justice Its Form

It is tempting to arrange duty and love as successive moral systems. Justice would govern the beginner by rules; charity would free the mature person to leave rules behind. The tradition refuses that sequence. Love does not prove its freedom by violating the good.

Aquinas calls charity the *form of the virtues*. He does not mean that justice, prudence, courage, or temperance lose their proper objects. Charity directs their acts toward the last end and gives them the form of acts belonging to friendship with God (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 8). Justice still renders what is due. Religion still renders worship to the first principle. Charity gives those acts their final Godward orientation (CCC 1827, 2095).

Because worship does not repair a divine lack, justice recognizes the Creator's excellence and the creature's received condition, while charity loves the One justice acknowledges. A person can therefore render what is due without reluctance, obey the command without mercenary calculation, and choose the act freely without making it optional.

Aquinas names peace as charity's proper effect. Justice causes peace indirectly by removing injuries and other obstacles; charity causes it directly by unifying desire in God and joining persons in one good (ST II–II, q. 29, a. 3). The peace of the wayfarer remains imperfect and can coexist with disturbance, dryness, and conflict. Its formal claim is not that the person always feels settled, but that desire need no longer be organized around resistance to the good.

Charity also exceeds the calculation of repayment. A debt can be treated as discharged once an equal measure has been returned. No creature can equal the gift of being, grace, or promised beatitude, and God has no need of compensation. Love therefore asks a different question from minimal compliance: not *when have I paid enough?*, but *what is the good of the beloved?* This does not cancel determinate obligations. It changes the horizon within which they are performed.

The neighbor is the necessary test. Paul says that love fulfills the law because it does no evil to the neighbor (Rom 13:8–10). The First Letter of John is more severe: one cannot claim love of the unseen God while hating the brother who is seen (1 John 4:20–21). Mystical language that terminates in fascination with one's own interior state has failed at the Johannine boundary.

Augustine's compressed instruction, "Love, and do what you will," is often made to say the opposite of its context. In

his seventh homily on First John, outwardly similar acts can arise from contrary roots: a harsh correction may seek a person's good, while a caress may conceal predation. Augustine does not authorize impulse. He demands that silence, speech, correction, and mercy proceed from charity, because an act is morally disclosed by the love from which it comes (*Homilies on First John* VII.8–9).

That root has objective form. Charity wills true good; it does not call evil good in order to appear gentle. It can correct without hatred, forgive without denying injury, and suffer with another without making suffering desirable. The Cross governs the meaning of charity. Divine love is manifested not as indiscriminate affirmation but in the Father sending the Son so that sinners may live, and in the Son freely laying down his life for those who did not first love him (1 John 4:9–11; John 10:17–18).

The shape is therefore both contemplative and ordinary. To adore, keep faith, tell truth, restore what is owed, feed the hungry, forgive an enemy, bear another's burden, and accept correction can all be informed and commanded by charity. Their finitude is not an embarrassment. The love of God is tested precisely where the received good of another person makes a claim upon my will.

Justice answers: *this good is due*. Charity answers: *I will it for the beloved in God*.

Love goes beyond the calculation of debt. It never falls beneath justice.

5 Whole, Though Not Equal

The gift does not stop before the answer. If charity were produced by the creature alone, the final return would break the asymmetry with which the trilogy began. The creature would receive being and law from God while reserving, as an independent possession, the power by which it answered. The doctrine of grace denies that hidden reserve. What is most inward and most free remains gift.

This is why friendship with God is more than the moral improvement of a naturally complete agent. The Father sends the Son; the Spirit is given; the adopted child is brought into a communion no creature can demand or reach by proportionate natural power (Rom 5:5; 8:14–17; Gal 4:4–7). The missions of the Son and Spirit reveal the divine initiative and communicate grace; they introduce neither need nor change into God (ST I, q. 43, aa. 1–3).

The Holy Spirit is not an impersonal energy added between God and the creature. In Aquinas's Trinitarian grammar, love is said essentially of the one God and personally of the Spirit as proceeding Love (ST I, q. 37, aa. 1–2). Created charity is neither the divine essence nor the Person of the Spirit. It is a created effect of grace, a participation through which the Spirit unites the creature to God and forms the creature's own act of love.

Pseudo-Dionysius describes love as ecstatic: it carries the lover beyond self-enclosure toward the beloved. The Good is at once the source and end of love's movement: created love proceeds under divine giving and returns toward the Good from which every power to love derives (*Divine Names* IV.13–14). Ecstasy here is not loss of personhood, emotional transport, or necessary emanation. It is the will's refusal to remain its own final measure.

Bernard of Clairvaux gives the return its Christian intimacy. In *Sermon on the Song of Songs* 83, the soul is conformed to the Word by loving because it has been loved. God is feared as Lord, honored as Father, and loved as Bridegroom; love frees fear from servility and honor from flattery. Bernard then removes every suggestion of equality. A creature cannot answer divine power with power or divine judgment with judgment. In love alone it can return something like what it receives, *etsi non ex aequo*—though not on equal terms (83.3–6).

The inequality is not failure. The creature's return need not equal its source in order to be whole. In Bernard's account, the creature loves wholly by continuing to receive from the fountain. Its answer may be complete as self-gift without becoming commensurate with the uncreated gift that made the answer possible.

John of the Cross presses the same truth to its mystical limit. In the second redaction of the *Spiritual Canticle*, the soul desires not only to be loved but to love God with the love God communicates. God teaches and enables the act; the soul loves in the Holy Spirit. John can therefore speak of an equality or conformity in love (stanza 38.2–6). The equality is participated and received: he explicitly distinguishes union by communication and participation from unity of essence (39.4–6). Grace does not make another divine Person. It gives a creature a created share in Trinitarian life.

The return is therefore neither autonomous nor coerced. God is first cause of the graced act; the person is a real voluntary cause. Being is wholly received, yet genuinely mine. The due is objectively binding, yet freely rendered. Charity is wholly graced, yet genuinely mine.

The apprehension of dependence deepens. Alienation recedes.

Faith heard the self-disclosure it could not deduce. Hope relied upon the help it could not supply. Charity adheres to the One disclosed and hoped for, not merely as an object known from afar but as friend and final good. The theological virtues do not erase metaphysical dependence. They make that dependence the place of communion.

The creature does not climb out of reception. It receives the power to return.

6 At the End of Every Why

The command is not figurative. God is to be loved with the whole heart. Yet an external precept can name the good and expose refusal; it cannot of itself make the good beloved. The New Law does not lower the command. It gives, in the Holy Spirit, the capacity for a free answer.

Charity is that answer: friendship with God, not religious warmth or preference. The friend remains a creature. Christ remains Lord. What changes is not the asymmetry but the creature's relation to the good. Justice is not left behind; one who has begun to love the One whom justice acknowledges now renders the due freely.

The asymmetry has not narrowed. It has reached even the answer. God gives not only being and the good to be loved but the power to love him. The act is received and free: unequal to the divine love it answers, yet capable by grace of being whole.

Ontological vertigo is not resolved by discovering an independent ground beneath creaturehood. Its resolution begins when the will ceases to demand one. Stability is not self-possession over against God but adherence to the One upon whom the creature depends.

What charity removes is not reverence but alienation. Recoil gives way to adherence; service is taken into friendship; the infinite disproportion between Creator and creature becomes no obstacle to communion.

I give God nothing he lacks. The One whom nothing completes gives himself.

At the end of every creaturely why there is no higher law imposed upon God, no need behind his gift, no cause behind his being.

God is love.

A Scope, Method, and Qualifications

A.1 Reader, question, and method

This is Part III of *The Creature Before God*, a discursive moral- and spiritual-theological article for a serious general reader. It asks how love can be commanded and remain free, and how grace, friendship with God, transformed fear, peace, and mystical participation complete the trilogy's account of creaturely response.

The article is the final movement of a trilogy on creaturehood: received being, the justice of response, and the freedom of charity. It remains independently intelligible. Its central claim is neither that obligation becomes unreal nor that feeling completes the law. It argues that external precept names the good but does not by itself cause the inward charity by which the good is freely embraced. In charity, ontological asymmetry remains while alienation from the good begins to recede.

Source class	Function in the article	Governing boundary
Sacred Scripture	Governs the commands to love, the New Covenant promise, friendship, adoption, the missions of Son and Spirit, and charity's ethical test.	No isolated verse is made to supply a later technical distinction; the Johannine confession retains its Paschal and moral context.
Conciliar and catechetical teaching	Governs divine non-need, free creation, the theological virtues, grace as participation, and the New Law as love, grace, and freedom.	Authoritative synthesis is not reduced to one philosophical school or to a test of felt experience.
Patristic witness	Supplies Irenaeian liberty and friendship and Augustinian law, grace, and ethically rooted charity.	Exact loci govern; a Father's image is not treated as an exhaustive definition or authority count.
Thomistic theology	Provides the principal distinctions among command, voluntary motion, infused charity, friendship, filial fear, and charity as form of the virtues.	The adopted synthesis remains distinct from dogmatic definition where Catholic theology permits further schools and formulations.
Mystical and monastic witness	Articulates ecstatic return, Bernard's unequal reciprocity, and John's participated conformity in love.	No image promises experience, implies emanation, or erases the distinction between uncreated source and graced creature.
Project synthesis	Orders command, grace, friendship, transformed fear, peace, and return into a concluding movement from formal analysis to poetic compression.	"Resolution," "stability without symmetry," and the final formulations belong to this article and add no premise to the theological argument.

A.2 Included and excluded scope

Included are the commands to love God and neighbor; the distinction between external precept and inward grace; the New Law; noncoercive divine motion of the will; infused charity as friendship with God; the transition from servile fear to filial reverence and secure wonder; charity as the direct cause of peace and form of the virtues; the Cross and neighbor as tests of love; and mystical return in Pseudo-Dionysius, Bernard, and John of the Cross.

Excluded are a complete treatise on law, grace, justification, merit, predestination, assurance, sacraments, moral culpability, or the loss and restoration of charity; a catalogue of moral, ecclesiastical, or canonical precepts; a full theology of counsels and religious life; and disputed questions about extraordinary mystical states. The article neither infers a person's state of grace from feeling nor composes a prayer for vocal recitation.

A.3 Material qualifications

1. Charity can be commanded because union with God is the due end of spiritual life. This does not mean that coercion produces charity; the act required by the precept must be voluntary (ST II–II, q. 44, a. 1).
2. External law remains good and necessary. Its inability to heal the will by itself distinguishes precept from assisting and sanctifying grace; it does not oppose grace to doctrine, ecclesial teaching, or sacramental mediation.
3. The New Law is chiefly the grace of the Holy Spirit and secondarily written instruction disposing persons to grace and directing its use (ST I–II, q. 106, a. 1). “Interior” does not mean private or subjective.
4. Charity is an infused theological virtue and a created habit, not natural affection, emotional intensity, the divine essence, or the Person of the Holy Spirit (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 2; q. 24, a. 2).
5. Grace neither bypasses nor coerces the will. God moves voluntary causes according to their voluntary mode; even the free turning toward grace depends upon gratuitous inward motion, and a graced act can be wholly dependent and genuinely the person’s act (ST I–II, q. 10, a. 4; q. 109, a. 6).
6. No antecedent merit of the recipient earns initial justification or the first sanctifying grace. This does not deny Christ’s merit or the merit of acts already proceeding from grace (CCC 1992, 2010).
7. Friendship with God rests on God’s gratuitous communication of beatitude. It implies neither equality of nature nor satisfaction of a need in God (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 1).
8. Charity removes servility, not divine lordship, determinate obligation, or filial reverence. Fear of punishment may remain while filial fear grows with love; the wholly secure wonder of ST II–II, q. 19, a. 11 describes the blessed, not a guaranteed present affect.
9. Ontological vertigo is not identified with servile fear, filial fear, or the gift of fear. Aquinas’s distinctions illuminate the response analogically; the project’s term is initially pre-moral.
10. Charity’s peace unifies desire objectively but remains imperfect in the wayfarer. Dryness, disturbance, and conflict can coexist with charity; no sensible serenity is promised (ST II–II, q. 29, a. 3).
11. Charity is the form of the virtues because it directs their acts to the supernatural final end. It does not erase their proper objects or turn justice, religion, and prudence into undifferentiated benevolence (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 8).
12. Charity exceeds calculation of repayment but never falls beneath justice. A loving intention cannot make an intrinsically evil object good or erase morally relevant circumstances.
13. Augustine’s instruction “Love, and do what you will” is read within his contrast between acts rooted in charity and acts that only appear gentle. It does not canonize impulse, permissiveness, or private preference.
14. Johannine charity is Trinitarian, Paschal, and ethically tested: the Father sends the Son, the Spirit is given, and claimed love of God is tested in love of the visible neighbor.
15. Pseudo-Dionysian ecstasy means movement beyond self-enclosure toward the beloved, not emotional transport, emanation, annihilation, or absorption.
16. Bernard’s unequal reciprocity and John of the Cross’s participated equality or conformity in love are compatible: the creature receives the very capacity by which it answers. “Whole” concerns graced self-gift, not equality of essence, source, power, or causal priority.
17. Love is said essentially of the one God and personally of the Holy Spirit according to relation of origin. Created charity is an effect of grace and a created participation, not an identification of the soul with proceeding Love (ST I, q. 37, aa. 1–2).
18. The exact phrase “God is love” occurs in 1 John 4:8 and 4:16, not in the Gospel of John. It is neither reversed into “love is God” nor presented as a natural demonstration of Trinity.

A.4 Translations, rights, currentness, and review

Scriptural language is limited to short traditional or working-English phrases. Patristic and mystical checking used the identified public-domain ANF, NPNF, Parker, Eales, and Lewis–Zimmerman witnesses. Thomas is cited by work, question, article, and reply; governing Latin loci were checked in the Corpus Thomisticum where identified, with

public English used as a working aid. Source wording and third-party translations remain outside the project’s CC BY 4.0 grant; the surrounding synthesis is project-created.

The core online witnesses were checked through 20 July 2026; the added Augustinian and Thomistic loci were checked on 21 July 2026. No mutable discipline, jurisdiction-specific rule, or current legal conclusion governs the central argument. The article has undergone internal theological and literary review. The publication has not received independent moral-theological, patristic, Thomistic, mystical-theological, dogmatic, literary, or ecclesiastical review and claims no ecclesiastical approval.

B References

Sacred Scripture

- Deut 6:4–5; Jer 31:31–34; Ezek 36:26–27; Matt 22:37–40; John 10:17–18 and 15:9–17; Rom 5:5, 8:14–17, and 13:8–10; Gal 4:4–7; 2 Pet 1:4; 1 John 4:7–21.
- The exact confession “God is love” occurs at 1 John 4:8 and 4:16, not in the Gospel of John. It is read within the complete unit’s account of the Father’s initiative, the Son’s mission, the gift of the Spirit, the command to love, and the visible neighbor as ethical test; working English witness.

Authoritative Catholic witnesses

- First Vatican Council, dogmatic constitution *Dei Filius* (24 April 1870), ch. 1 and canon 1.5, DS 3002 and 3025: free creation to manifest divine perfection through goods bestowed rather than to acquire or increase divine beatitude; official Latin.
- *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1812–1829 (theological virtues, charity, commandment, friendship, form of the virtues, and spiritual freedom); official English.
- *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1965–1974, especially 1972 (the New Law as law of love, grace, and freedom); official English.
- *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1987–1995, especially 1992, on justification through the merit of Christ’s Passion; official English.
- *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1996–2005 (grace as gratuitous participation in divine life, free response, and the limits of experiential assurance), official English; 2095–2097 (charity informing religion, justice toward God, and adoration), official English.
- *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 2006–2011, especially 2010, on Christ’s prior merit, the impossibility of meriting initial grace, and merit within grace; official English.

Patristic witnesses

- St. Irenaeus of Lyons, *Against Heresies* IV.13.1–4, on fulfillment of the natural precepts, the greater obedience of liberty, and servants made friends, ANF working English; IV.14.1, on service benefiting the creature rather than the God who needs nothing, working English.
- St. Augustine of Hippo, *On the Spirit and the Letter* 32–36, on external precept, the inward Spirit, and charity fulfilling the law, NPNF working English; *Confessions* X.29.40, for the brief traditional petition asking God to give what he commands.
- Augustine, *Homilies on the First Epistle of John* VII.8–9, on correction, mercy, and acts proceeding from the root of charity, working English; IX.4–6, on fear of punishment and chaste fear within love, working English.

Thomistic framework

- St. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I–II, q. 10, a. 4 (divine motion according to the voluntary mode); q. 106, a. 1 (the New Law chiefly as grace of the Holy Spirit); q. 109, aa. 3–4 and 6 (healing grace, love of God under fallen nature, and gratuitous motion in the free turning toward grace).
- Aquinas, ST II–II, q. 19, aa. 10–11 (servility expelled, fear of punishment diminishing, filial reverence increasing, and secure wonder in beatitude); q. 23, aa. 1–3, 5, and 8 (friendship, created charity, virtue, love of God and neighbor, and charity as form); q. 24, a. 2 (infusion); q. 29, a. 3 (charity as the direct cause of peace); q. 44, aa. 1–5, especially a. 1 ad 2 (the command of love and liberty).
- Aquinas, ST I, q. 19, aa. 2–4 and q. 20, aa. 1–2 (divine non-need, free willing of creatures, and divine love); q. 37, aa. 1–2 (Love as essential and personal name); q. 43, aa. 1–3 (missions and eternal processions).
- Latin loci checked in the Corpus Thomisticum Leonine-text corpus; the New Advent Summa was used as a working public English index. Work, question, article, and reply take precedence over either site’s wording.

Monastic and mystical witnesses

- Pseudo-Dionysius, *Divine Names* IV.13–14, on ecstatic love and return toward the Good. John Parker, trans., *The Works of Dionysius the Areopagite*, vol. 1 (London: James Parker, 1897), public-domain working edition. The author is identified according to modern convention rather than as the convert of Acts 17.
- St. Bernard of Clairvaux, *Sermons on the Song of Songs* 83.3–6, on love returning to its divine source, freedom from servility, and the creature’s unequal answer. The Latin was checked in *Sancti Bernardi Opera*, vol. 2, 300–302, with a stable online witness; Samuel J. Eales’s 1895 English was used only as a public-domain aid.
- St. John of the Cross, *Spiritual Canticle* B, stanza 38.2–6 and 39.4–6, second redaction, on God giving the capacity for participated equality or conformity in love through the Holy Spirit and on union by participation rather than identity of essence. David Lewis, trans., Benedict Zimmerman, rev. (1909), stanza 38 and stanza 39, public-domain working edition.

C Generation Metadata

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Model: GPT-5-based Codex **agent; unexposed:** exact model identifier and model qualifiers

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (patristic, Thomistic, mystical-theological, source-audit, drafting, and literary-review roles); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (series-wide grammatical, semantic, theological-weight, literary, source-consistency, drafting, typesetting, and production-review roles); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

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